

**Project Proposal:**  
**Optional Digital & Social Workshop for Older Adults**

**Organization:** Semper Avanti (Opole, Poland)

**Proposed Activity:** Optional Recreational Digital & Social Workshop

**Document Type:** Volunteer Initiative Proposal

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## 1. Project Overview

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This proposal outlines an optional, recreational workshop concept designed for older adults participating in activities supported by Semper Avanti in Opole. The primary purpose is to introduce simple, everyday mobile technology—specifically smartphones and tablets—not as an academic or technical subject, but as a practical tool to support human connection, social engagement, and personal confidence.

The workshop is designed to be fully adaptable, non-formal, and participant-led. Rather than focusing on technical mastery, the activity aims to help older adults explore digital tools at their own pace in an encouraging, low-pressure environment. This project is proposed as an open concept to be reviewed, adjusted, or restructured according to the priorities of Semper Avanti and the needs of the participants.

## 2. Background and Rationale

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In modern society, daily communication, media access, and family interactions increasingly rely on digital channels. For older adults, navigating smart devices can sometimes present an unnecessary barrier, leading to a sense of disconnect from modern communication trends.

This initiative addresses this dynamic by offering a safe, supportive space where older adults can experiment with simple device functions. The initiative is rooted in the understanding that digital devices—when introduced with patience and respect—can serve as simple bridges to strengthen existing relationships with family members, friends, and the wider community, potentially helping to reduce feelings of social routine isolation.

### 3. Main Objectives

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- **Support Social Connection:** Assist participants in using basic tools (e.g., messaging, photo sharing, video calls) to communicate more comfortably with relatives and peers.
- **Encourage Digital Confidence:** Demystify smartphones and tablets by creating a friendly environment where participants feel safe to try basic features without fear of making mistakes.
- **Provide an Enjoyable Recreational Space:** Offer a meaningful, relaxed social activity that prioritizes personal interaction, sharing stories, and shared enjoyment over curriculum goals.
- **Maintain Participant-Centered Flexibility:** Adapt all content dynamically to match the individual energy, interests, and comfort levels of participants in each session.

### 4. Target Participants & Group Dynamics

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The workshop is designed for older adults who express interest in learning or improving basic smartphone or tablet operations.

- **Voluntary Participation:** Attendance and participation are entirely optional. Participants may join, observe, or leave at any point.
- **Group Size:** Small, informal gatherings are recommended to ensure every participant receives personal attention and can work at a comfortable pace.
- **Tailored Engagement:** Content will be tailored to individual starting points—offering basic hands-on guidance to complete beginners while suggesting varied, practical activities for participants with prior device familiarity.

## 5. Core Workshop Philosophy

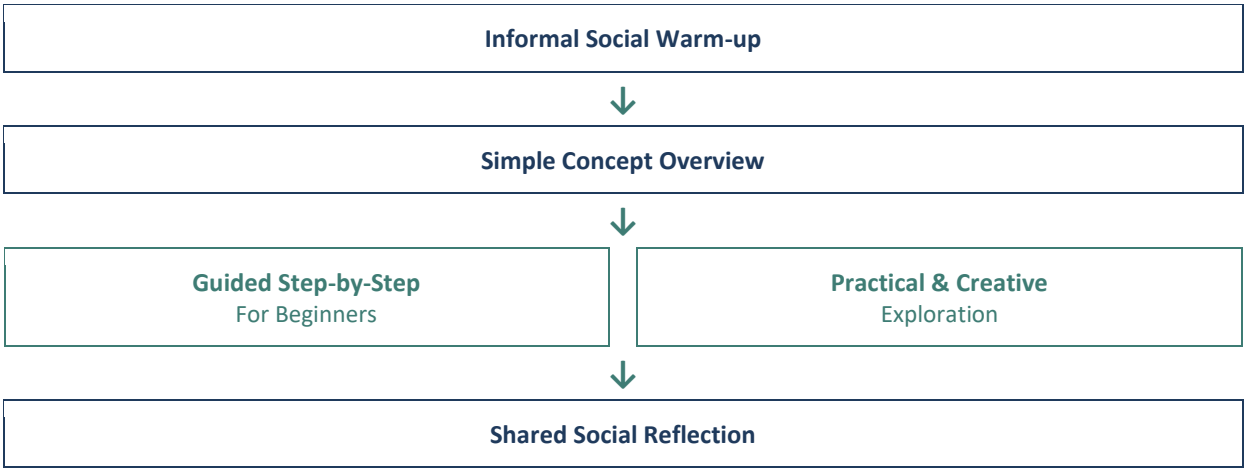
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The design of this workshop is guided by key human-centered principles:

- **Dignity and Comfort First:** The physical and emotional well-being of participants always takes precedence over completing an activity or lesson plan.
- **No Examinations, No Pressure:** This is a purely recreational activity. Participants will never be tested, evaluated, or placed in situations that induce anxiety.
- **Normalizing Mistakes:** Trial and error are framed as a standard, positive part of learning. Mistakes are treated with patience and lighthearted encouragement.
- **Flexibility to Pause or Stop:** If participants show signs of fatigue, discomfort, or distraction, the activity will immediately adapt, pause, shorten, or shift toward general conversation.

## 6. Proposed Approach and Methodology

The proposed methodology is conversational and practical, focusing primarily on handheld devices (smartphones and tablets) rather than desktop computers, as mobile devices are generally more accessible in daily life.



The approach emphasizes small, manageable steps:

- **Observation & Touch:** Familiarizing participants with device gestures, screens, and simple settings.
- **Contextual Learning:** Linking every device feature directly to a practical, real-world action (e.g., using the camera to capture a memory, or using a map app to look up a familiar town).
- **Patience and Repetition:** Re-explaining steps as often as needed without rush, ensuring participants maintain full agency over their devices.

## 7. Possible Educational Areas (Flexible Examples)

The following topics represent potential areas of exploration. They do not constitute a fixed curriculum and will be chosen based on participant feedback and supervisor approval:

| Category                | Potential Topics / Activities                                                                          |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Device Basics           | Understanding touch screens, volume/brightness controls, power buttons, and basic navigation.          |
| Photography & Media     | Using the camera, viewing photo galleries, and organizing personal photos.                             |
| Basic Communication     | Sending simple text messages, understanding messaging interfaces, and setting up video calls.          |
| Information & Curiosity | Searching for topics of interest online, exploring interactive maps, or listening to music on YouTube. |
| Family Connection       | Exploring practical ways to receive or view photos and updates sent by children or grandchildren.      |

### Note on Digital Safety

*Complex safety topics will not form part of the initial sessions. If supervisors deem it appropriate, basic guidelines regarding digital safety and fraud prevention can be gently introduced in later sessions as a supplementary topic.*

## 8. Human and Social Dimension

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Technology in this project is treated strictly as a means to an end, not the final objective. Every technical exercise is structured around a human narrative:

- **Example:** An exercise on taking and sending a photograph is not merely about tapping a screen; it serves as a prompt for participants to share stories about the object, person, or memory captured in the picture.
- **Fostering Conversation:** Technical tasks are designed to naturally spark dialogue, encourage storytelling, and build rapport among participants and host volunteers.

## 9. Example Session Structure

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Sessions are envisioned to last between 45 to 60 minutes, though actual timing will remain entirely flexible based on group energy.

| Phase                   | Core Activity & Focus                                |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Welcome & Coffee     | Informal greeting, relaxed discussion, checking in.  |
| 2. Topic Introduction   | Brief, simple introduction of a single idea/feature. |
| 3. Guided Practice      | One-on-one or small-group hands-on exploration.      |
| 4. Social Sharing       | Group conversation linked to the activity.           |
| 5. Wrap-up & Reflection | Optional recap, gathering feedback for next time.    |



## 10. Role of the Volunteer & Team Integration

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- **Cooperation with Staff:** I will always talk with my supervisors before starting any new activity or bringing in new ideas. I rely on their knowledge of the participants to make sure whatever we do is appropriate and helpful.
- **Peer Collaboration:** I am really looking forward to working alongside the local staff and other volunteers. Having them join in, share their feedback, or help host the sessions will make the activities much better for everyone.
- **Preparation Phase:** Before jumping into any structured sessions, my main focus will be spending simple, informal time with the older adults—chatting over coffee and getting to know them so we can build real trust and feel comfortable with each other.

## 11. Volunteer Learning & Preparation Background

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- **Technical Background:** As a student in my final semester of Telecommunication Engineering, I have a natural, practical comfort with electronic devices and general technology. This background simply helps me stay patient and comfortable with devices, and it gives me practice breaking down tech concepts into simple, easy-to-understand steps.
- **Active Listening:** I have done basic non-formal preparation in active listening—learning how to pay full attention, give space without rushing, and use supportive, respectful communication so people feel genuinely heard and comfortable.
- **Awareness of Aging & Dementia Dynamics:** I have also taken time to learn basic introductory concepts about aging, family dynamics, and general communication awareness related to dementia, simply to help me be more thoughtful and considerate in how I interact with older adults.
- **Clarification:** I want to make clear that this preparation is just to help me be a more empathetic and respectful volunteer. I am not a medical, psychological, or healthcare professional.

## 12. Possible Future Cultural & Social Ideas

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Depending on the success of the initial activities and subject to supervisor guidance, additional cross-cultural and social initiatives could be explored in the future:

- **Syrian-Polish Cultural Exchange:** A relaxed social session centered on sharing traditional Syrian tea, culinary customs, and hospitality traditions as a foundation for cultural conversation.
- **Intergenerational & Family Discussions:** Guided group dialogues exploring local family structures, traditions, and the evolving roles of grandparents across different cultures.
- **Nature & Community Walks:** Simple outdoor gatherings or light local walks where participants can take photos and share memories in an informal environment.

### Note

*These represent potential ideas for future discussion and will only be pursued if deemed aligned with Semper Avanti's program goals.*

## 13. Flexibility, Feedback, and Evaluation

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This proposal is designed to be fully iterative:

- **Supervisor Decision-Maker Role:** Semper Avanti supervisors maintain full authority to approve, modify, scale down, or decline any part of this proposal.
- **Continuous Adjustment:** After each session, informal reflection will take place to assess what worked well and what should be simplified or changed.
- **Open Outcomes:** Success is not measured by curriculum completion, but by the comfort, engagement, and positive experience expressed by the participants.

## 14. Conclusion

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This project proposal aims to offer a practical, human-centered activity that uses basic technology to foster social warmth, personal confidence, and meaningful connection for older adults at Semper Avanti. By combining technical familiarity with patient, active listening and a commitment to participant dignity, the volunteer hopes to contribute constructively to the organization's ongoing community activities.

The initiative remains fully open to supervisor review, adaptation, and ongoing collaboration.